



Grade 8 SS History

1. The Mineral Revolution in South Africa

Learning Guide

Introduction

- The **Industrial Revolution in South Africa** began due to the **mining of diamonds and gold**.
- It is called the **Mineral Revolution** because it focused on the **mining of minerals**.
- It started after:
 - **Diamonds** were discovered in **Kimberley (1867)**
 - **Gold** was discovered on the **Witwatersrand (1886)**
- By the time gold was discovered:
 - **African kingdoms had lost their independence**
- The gold-mining revolution:
 - Laid the foundations for **racial segregation**
 - Ensured **white control over black South Africans**
- The discovery of gold was:
 - One of the **most important turning points in South African history**
- It transformed South Africa from:
 - An **agricultural society**
 - Into the **largest gold-producing country in the world**
- The city of **Johannesburg** was established:
 - Also called **Egoli ("city of gold")**

1. Increasing Labour Control

Migrant Labour

- Discovery of diamonds led to a **huge demand for labour**.
- This caused a rise in **African migrant workers** travelling to and from the **diamond fields**.
- Africans worked for **cash wages** to:
 - Buy **guns**
 - Buy **farming implements**
 - Pay **lobola (bride wealth)**

Compounds in the Early Years (from 1876)

- Diamond mining companies:
 - **Housed black workers separately in company compounds**
 - Kept them away from **white diggers**
- There was **some control**, but:
 - **Conditions were poor**
 - Workers suffered from **pneumonia in cold winters**
 - Caused by **lack of adequate food and shelter**

Closed Compounds (from 1885)

- Larger mining companies introduced the **closed compound system** for **all black workers**.
- Closed compounds:
 - Were built **on mining sites**
 - Used to **confine workers** during their **3–6 month contracts**

Reasons for Closed Compounds

- To:
 - **Improve living conditions** and increase **worker productivity**
 - **Increase control over workers**
 - Prevent **Illicit Diamond Buying (IDB)**

Controlling Illicit Diamond Buying (IDB)

- Workers could **not leave the compounds**
 - Mine owners could:
 - **Search workers only once** at the **end of contracts** instead of after every shift
 - Since diamonds were often **swallowed** to smuggle them:
 - Fewer exit checks helped **reduce diamond theft**
 - After contracts ended:
 - Workers had to stay an **additional 8 days** in the compound
 - Were given a **strong laxative** to clear hidden diamonds
 - Had to wear **thick gloves** so they couldn't pick up and swallow diamonds again
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2. Land Dispossession and Defeat of African Kingdoms

- The British wanted to:
 - **Strengthen their position** in Southern Africa after diamonds were discovered
- Wealthy British investors:
 - Wanted to **invest in mining**
 - Pressured authorities to **control diamond-rich areas** and **recruit labour**
- To maintain control:
 - The British needed to **dispossess African kingdoms of their land**
- The **Boers**:
 - Also wanted more **land and labourers**
 - Were **not strong enough** to defeat African kingdoms
 - Encouraged the **British to fight them**

African Kingdoms Defeated

- After long wars, the following were defeated:
 - **Xhosa – 1878**
 - **Pedi – 1879**
 - **Zulu – 1879**

Impact of Defeat

- Africans:
 - Could no longer **farm independently**
 - Were **forced to work for wages**
 - On **white farms**
 - Or in **diamond mines**
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3. Conditions Underground

- South African gold mines:
 - Are among the **deepest in the world**
 - Extend more than **3 km below the surface**
- Conditions underground:
 - Temperatures reach up to **60°C**
 - Floors covered in **dirty, stagnant water**
 - Work is **hard, uncomfortable, and very dangerous**

Major Dangers

- **Rock falls** from mine roofs and walls
- **Accidents with dynamite**

- **Health problems** from fine rock dust:
 - **Tuberculosis (TB)**
 - **Silicosis**

Coping Mechanisms

- Miners:
 - **Sang songs** to lift their spirits
- **“Shosholoza”**:
 - Traditional miner’s song
 - Originally sung by workers travelling from **Zimbabwe to South Africa**
 - Helped with:
 - **Rhythm**
 - **Boredom**
 - **Stress relief**

Key Takeaways

- ✓ The Mineral Revolution began with **diamonds and gold**
 - ✓ It led to **labour control systems** like compounds
 - ✓ Africans were **forced into wage labour**
 - ✓ African kingdoms were **defeated and dispossessed**
 - ✓ Mining conditions were **extremely dangerous**
 - ✓ Workers developed **ways to cope**, like singing
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